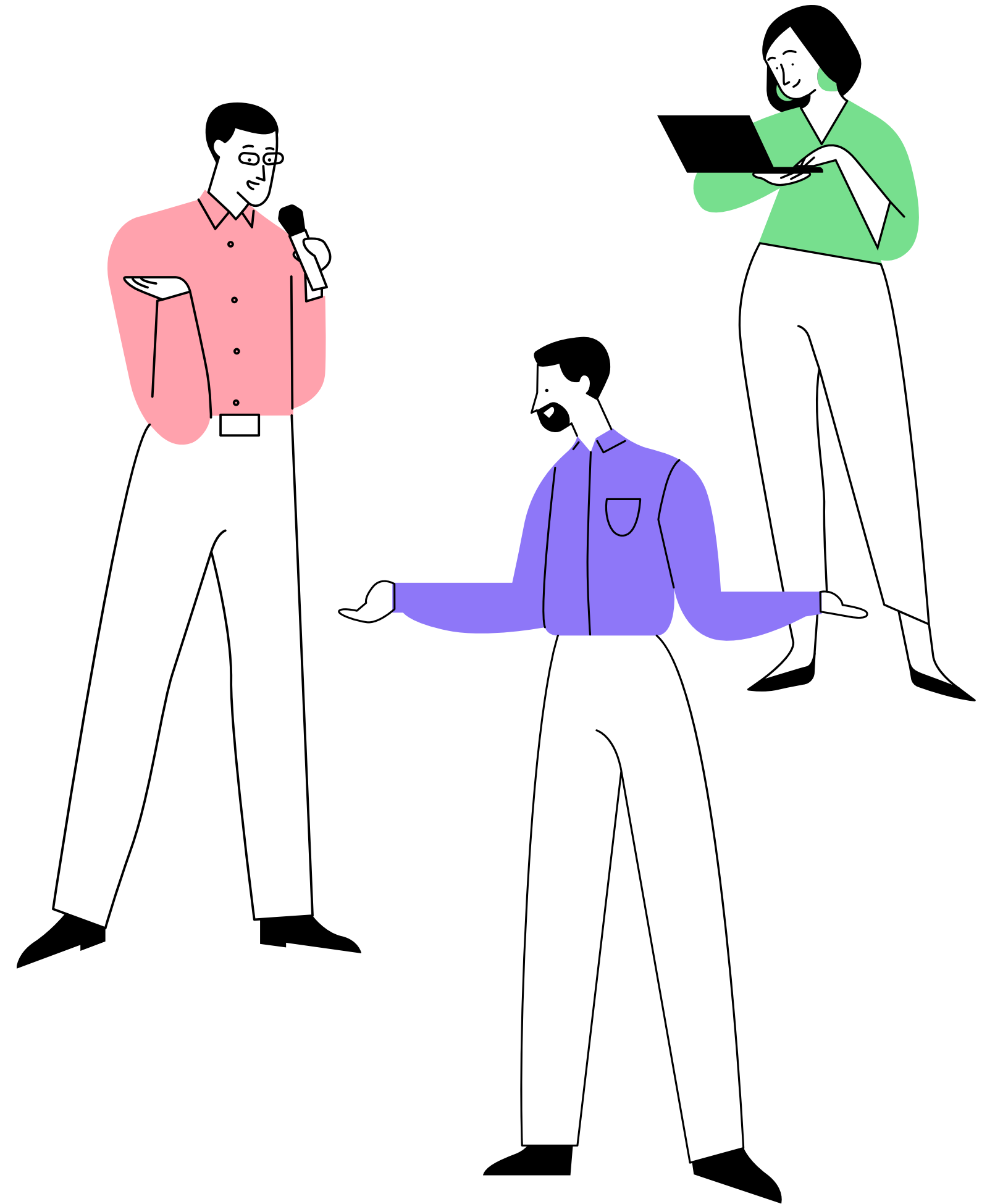


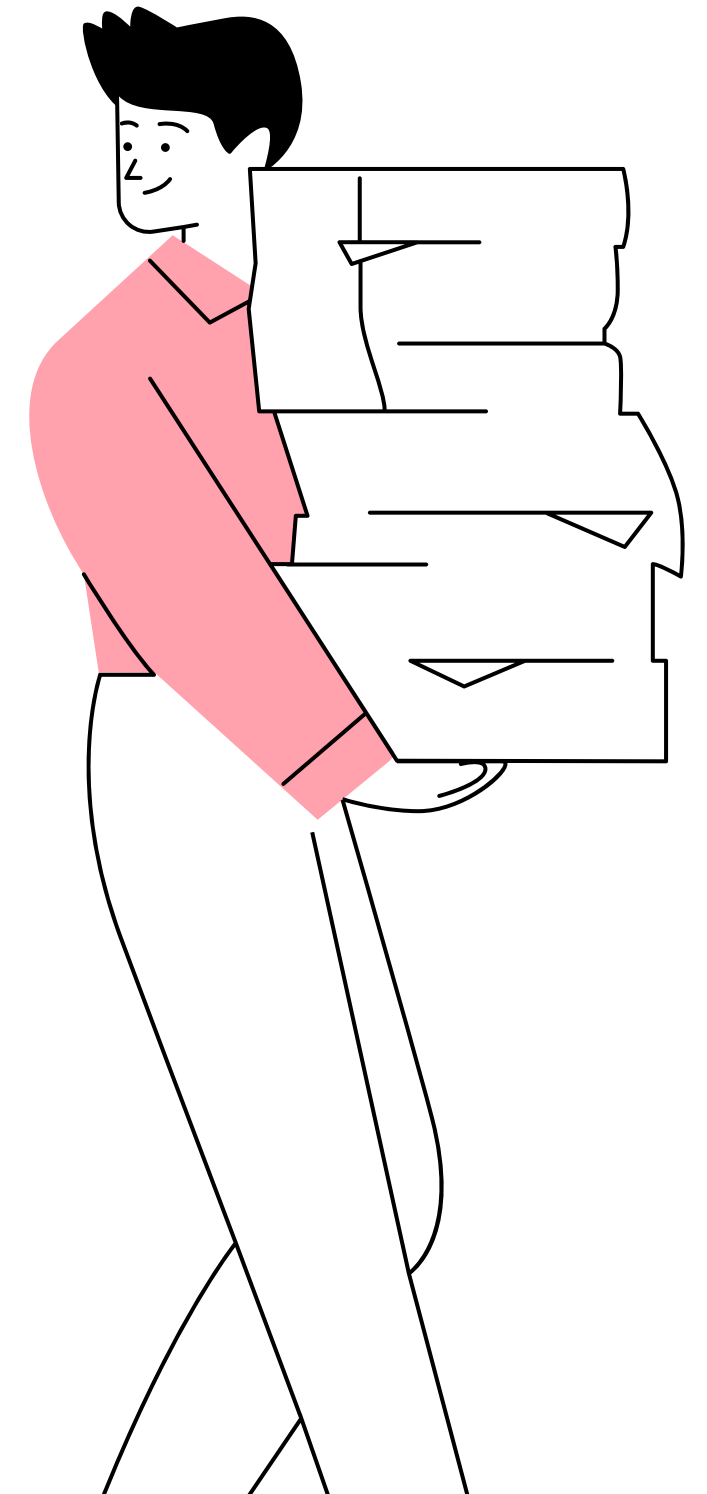
MICE Planners





Individuals or groups who sponsor meetings usually appoint a single individual or committee to coordinate the meeting. The person coordinating the meeting is called several names – MICE planner, meeting planner, meeting manager, coordinator, meeting director, and professional congress organizer (PCO).

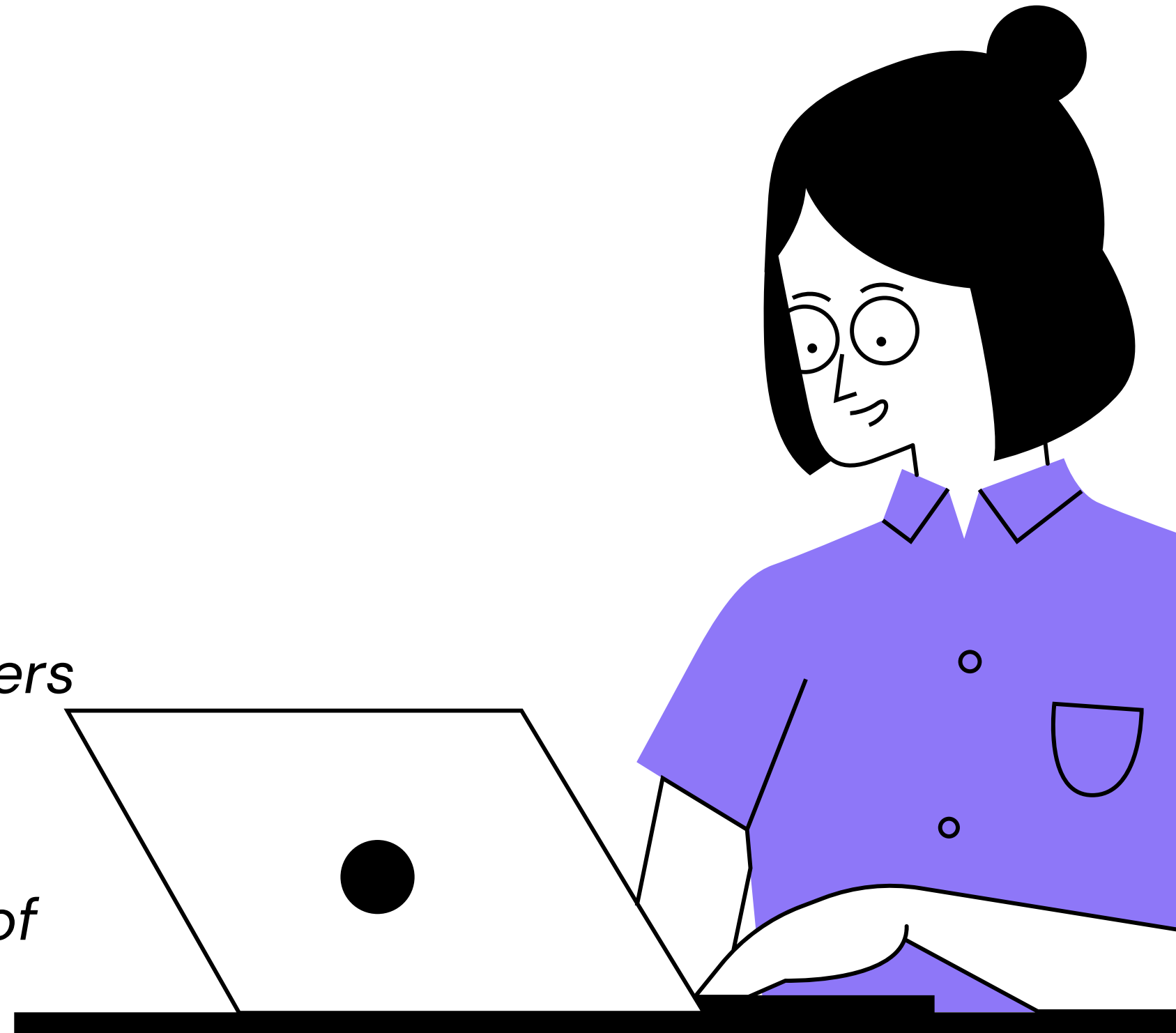
Characteristics and Responsibilities of MICE Planners



10 personality characteristics of successful MICE planners:

- 1.Organized
- 2.Efficient
- 3.Responsive
- 4.Attentive
- 5.Intelligent
- 6.Prompt
- 7.Courteous
- 8.Hardworking
- 9.Friendly
10. Hospitable

Majority of association and corporate meeting planners are between the ages of 35 and 55. More than 50 percent are women and 66 percent have a college education. Most of them have more than four years of experience in the field.



Responsibilities of MICE Planners

In general, MICE planners are responsible for the following:

Pre-meeting Activities:

1. Plan the agenda of the meeting
2. Establish the objectives of the meeting
3. Predict the attendance
4. Set the budget of the meeting
5. Select the site of the meeting
6. Select the meeting facility
7. Select the hotel
8. Negotiate contracts
9. Plan exhibition
10. Prepare the exhibitor correspondence and packet
11. Create a marketing plan
12. Plan travel to and from the site
13. Arrange ground transportation
14. Organize shipping
15. Organize audiovisual needs



ON-SITE ACTIVITIES:

1. Conduct pre-event briefing
2. Prepare executive plan
3. Move people in/ out
4. Troubleshoot
5. Approve invoices

POST-MEETING ACTIVITIES:

1. Debrief
2. Evaluate
3. Provide recognition and appreciation
4. Arrange shipping
5. Plan for next year



These responsibilities may vary due to the nature of the association, corporation, or group that the planner is representing. In general, the association and corporate planners are responsible for all aspects of the meeting, including the agenda, while the independent meeting planner may only be responsible for certain aspects of the meeting, such as site selection, agenda planning budgetary matters, and negotiations.

Pre-meeting Activities:

The Meeting Agenda

Before a MICE planner can start planning the meeting, he or she must know why the meeting is being held. Meetings and conventions are often held for several reasons– training, problem-solving, brainstorming, planning, networking, team building, etc. If the MICE planner is involved in the meeting agenda, he or she should give advice with regard to the proper handling of specific types of meetings. For example, if the group sponsoring the meeting want team building experiences, the MICE planner will give advice on how this could be achieved through room setup, education, and recreational activities.

Meeting Objectives

The meeting agenda provides the basis for the establishment of objectives. The meeting objectives, in turn, will provide the groundwork for the budget, the site selection, and the site facility.

Budget of the Meeting

Setting a budget for the meeting is a difficult task. It is successful if the MICE planner is consulted before the budget is finalized. A working budget should be established and used as a guideline in making decisions. The planner should be consulted when changes in the budget are made. The budget should contain income and expenditures as thoroughly as possible. Many MICE planners have lost their clients or jobs because of their inability to hold the event within the established budget. Hence, it is very important that every possible expenditure is included in the budget before the event takes place.

Income for a meeting, convention, or exposition could include the following:

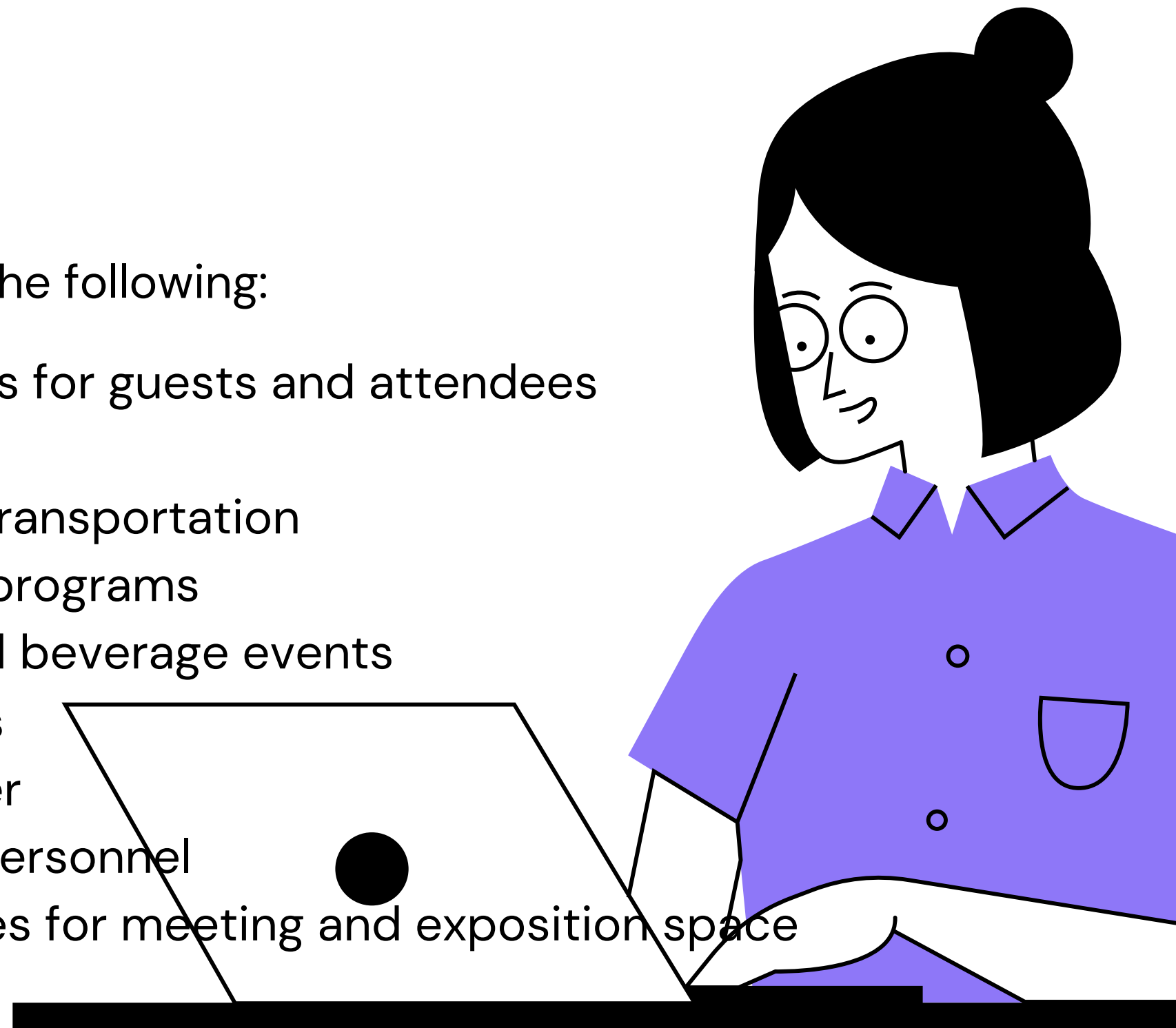
- 1.Registration fees
- 2.Exhibitor fees
3. Company or sponsoring organization money revenues

- 1.Advertising revenues
- 2.Revenues from the sale of educational materials
- 3.Event sponsor contributions
- 4.Registration fee interest
- 5.Grants or contributions

Expenses for a meeting, convention or exposition could include the following:

- 1.Meeting planner fees
- 2.Marketing expenses
- 3.Printing and copying expenses
- 4.Mailing
- 5.Shipping
- 6.Support supplies such as office supplies
- 7.Support staff
- 8.Audiovisual equipment
- 9.Signage
10. Speaker fees, honorarium, and expenses

11. Mementos for guests and attendees
- 12.Tours
13. Ground transportation
14. Spousal programs
15. Food and beverage events
- 16.Gratuities
- 17.Interpreter
- 18.On-site personnel
- 19.Rental fees for meeting and exposition space



ATTENDANCE

Attendance determines the success of a meeting or convention. To solicit attendance, the MICE planner should develop a marketing plan. To develop a marketing plan, the MICE planner must know what he or she and the sponsoring organization are marketing and who the prospective attendees are.

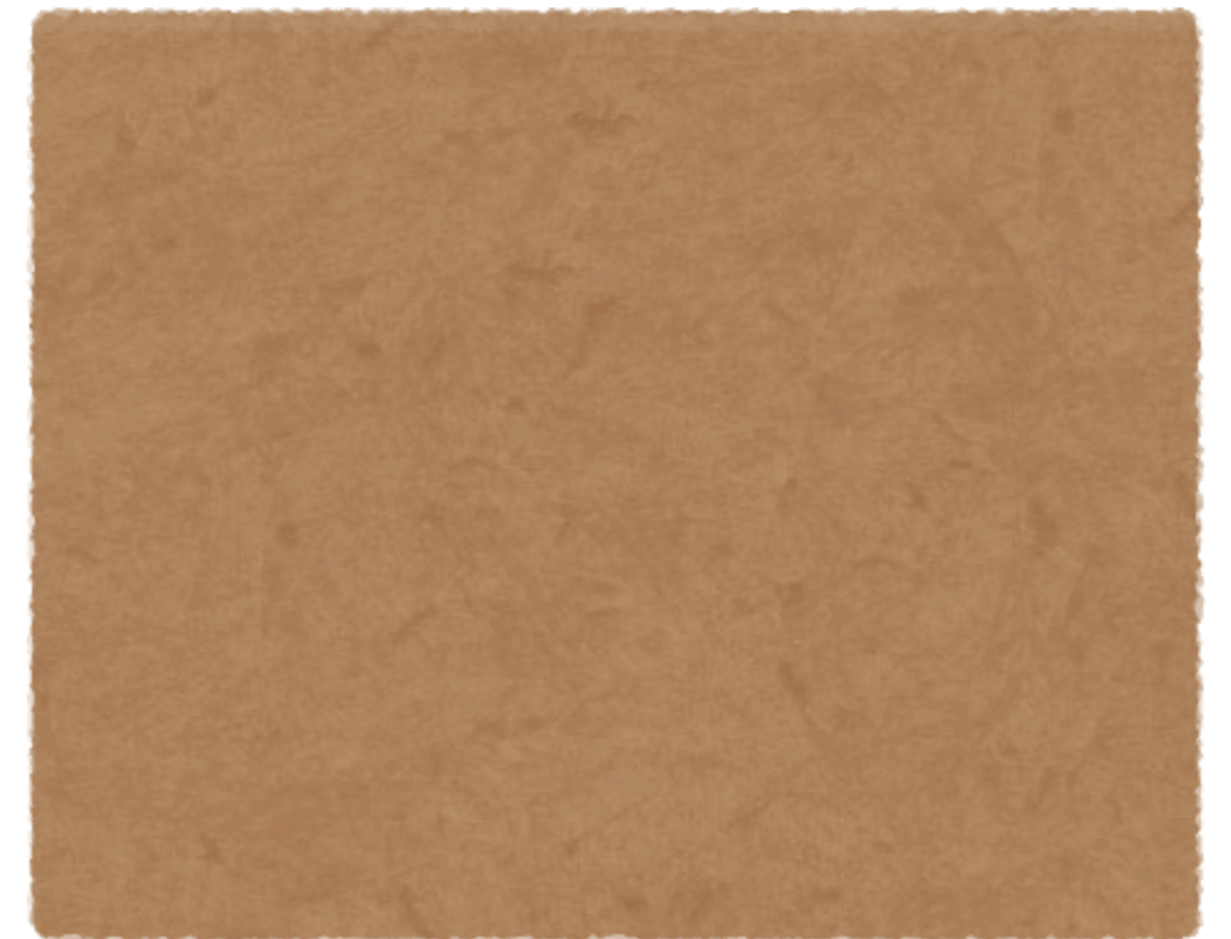
The work of the MICE planner is easier if he or she has a list of attendees and has demographic, psychographic, and historical data regarding past meeting participants. If the MICE planner is not familiar with the potential attendees, that person should develop a profile of them through discussions with the executive directors of the association or corporation. The planner must develop questionnaires to determine the needs, desires, and expectations of the group.

These questionnaires should be administered before the event.

The MICE planner should determine the marketing strategies that are best suited to the target market. Successful marketing planners must understand the importance of marketing their meetings and should allocate enough time and financial resources to successfully market meetings.

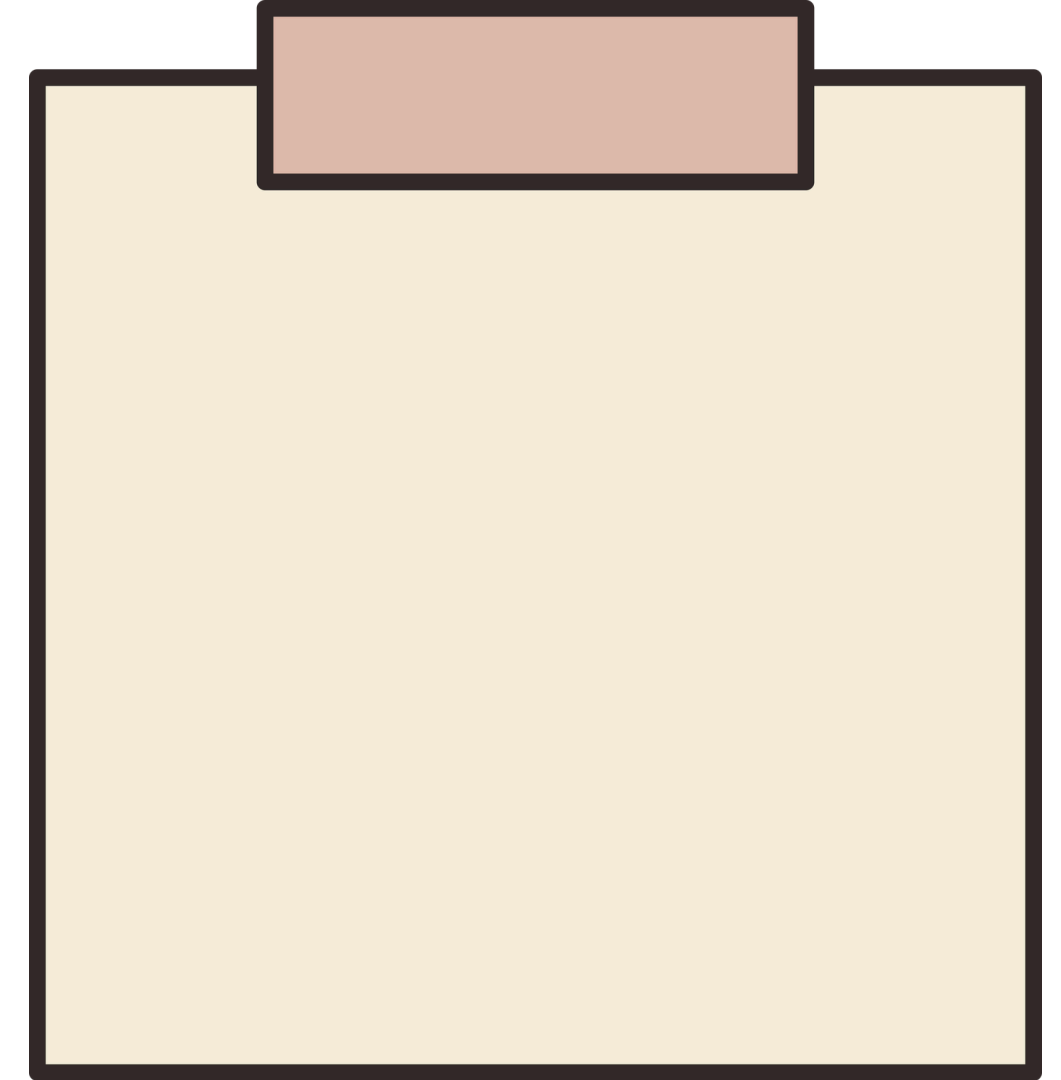
Site, Meeting Facility, and Hotel Selection

The success of a meeting, convention, or exposition depends on the site and facilities chosen. The selection of the site and meeting facility is based on the purpose of the meeting. The services provided by the site as well as the personnel and ambiance have a great influence on the attendees' perception of the event. Factors that determine the desirability of the site include airport access, ground transportation, number of meeting rooms and hotel rooms, as well as good services.



When selecting a host city, the following are the questions that should be answered:

1. Have you used the site before?
2. Is the site easily accessible for the majority of your participants?
3. Does the geographic area lend itself to pre- and post-meeting or conference excursions?
4. Is the ground transportation appropriate for the group?
5. What is the reputation of the site?
6. Is the climate acceptable to your participants?
7. Are there enough meeting spaces and sleeping rooms available to accommodate your group during the desired period?



When choosing the meeting facility and the hotel, service is the first priority. MICE planners must provide a level of service that makes the guests feel at home, well cared for, and anxious to return. Along with the service attitude of the staff, MICE planners are also looking for a higher level of services dietary needs, for their special attendees the physically handicapped and those with special dietary needs.



Another important area to be considered is the ability to meet the needs of their international attendees. The facilities, services, and amenities that have to be provided are multilingual staff, easy exchange of currency, interpreters, international codes and symbols on guest information and signage, and the ability to accommodate special dietary considerations.

When choosing the meeting facilities, the specific questions to be asked are:

1. Have you stayed in the facility before?
2. What have you heard from other groups with regard to this facility?
3. Is the facility accessible from the airport?
4. Is the physical appearance appealing?
5. Is the facility kept in good repair?
6. What kind of first impression does the facility make?
7. Does the facility have the needed space available?
8. What are the number, size, and caliber of meeting rooms and guest rooms?
9. Does the facility provide VIP accommodations?
10. Are nonsmoking rooms available?
11. Does the facility provide appropriate food and beverage services?
12. Does the facility provide appropriate recreational opportunities?
13. What time is check-in?

14. Can special arrangements be made for early check-in and late check-out?
15. Can special rates apply before the meeting and after the meeting in case the participants would like to arrive early or stay late?
16. What are the check-in and check-out procedures?
17. Are staff members appropriately dressed, knowledgeable, and courteous?
18. Does the facility provide the support staff the group will need to successfully host the meeting, convention, or exposition?
19. Is the signage appropriate?
20. What is the proximity of the facility to shopping, dining, and entertainment facilities?
21. Is the room rate appropriate for the group?
22. What kind of deposit is required?
23. What is the guarantee and cancellation policy?
24. What other groups will be on-site during your meeting?
25. What kind of room block will they provide?
26. Are the safety and security features working and up-to-date?

The person in charge of site selection should never sign a contract with a facility unit after just one site visit. It is suggested that the MICE planner makes two visits to the site—one announced and one unannounced. After the announced visit has been successfully completed, the MICE planner should visit the site unannounced, perhaps even using a different name. This visit will give the planner a view of how guests are usually treated. After completing the two site visitations, the planner can negotiate and sign the contract. After the site has been selected, the actual meeting, conference, or exhibition can be planned.

A detailed agenda can be made which will include meeting rooms and recreational activities. After this has been completed, the planner, together with the sponsoring organization should implement their marketing strategy.

In a corporate training meeting, the marketing may only be a flier or memo discussing the time, date, place, and agenda. If the event is a major convention, marketing starts one year before the event. In general, the convention is marketed in the registration packet of the previous year's convention. The type of information that should be included in the marketing piece should be dates, places, and a general overview of the theme. As the dates for the meeting, convention, or exhibition approaches, the marketing material should become more specific.

The MICE planner should also develop the exhibitor correspondence and packet. The exhibitor correspondence should include the correspondence sent to the registrants together with the information specific to the exhibition. The exhibitor packet may be developed by the MICE planner or by the exhibition manager.

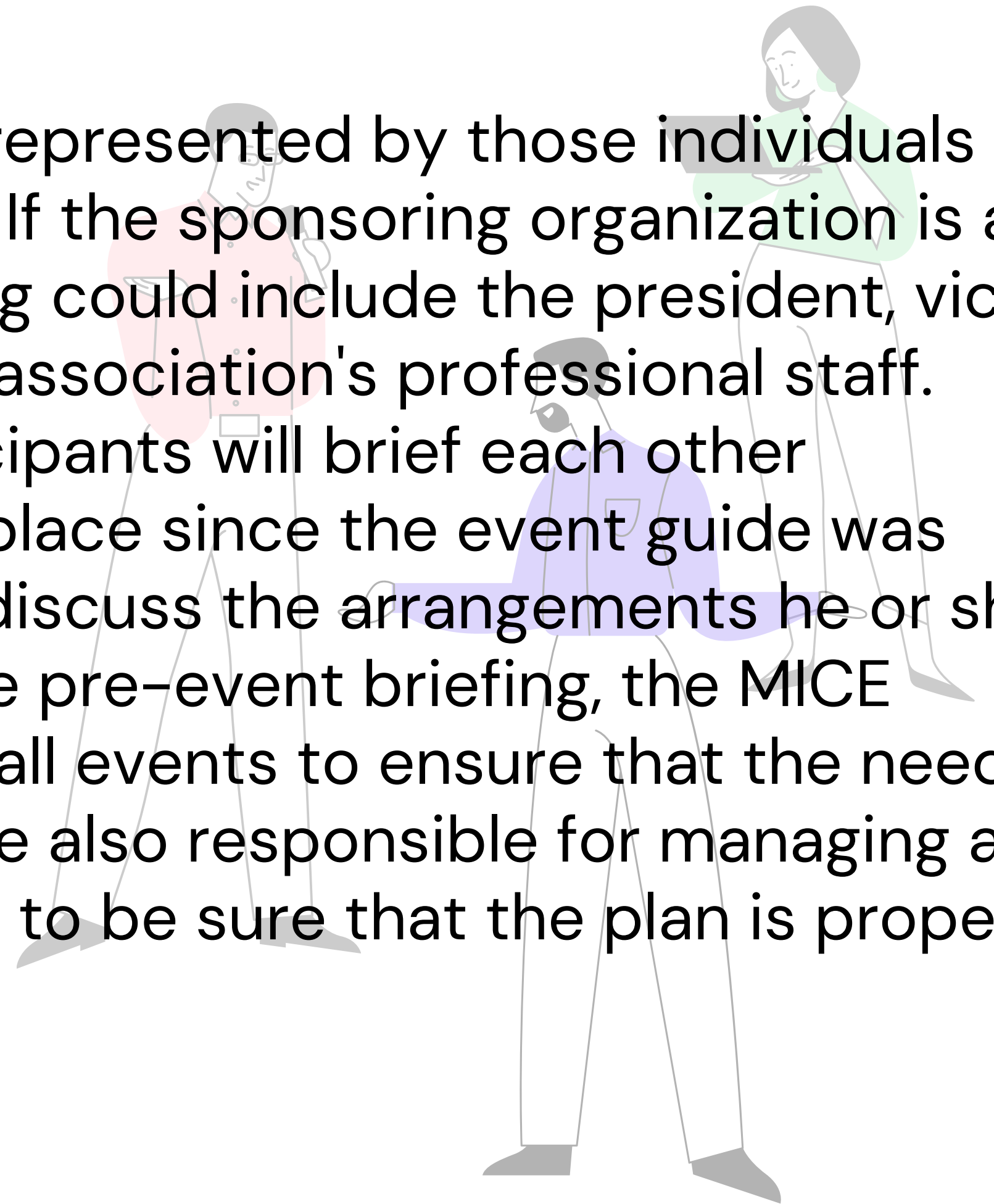
The last thing the MICE planner will be responsible for is to develop the final blueprint for the actual meeting, convention, or exhibition. This blueprint is often called the staging guide, staging book, planner's guide, planning book, or coordinator's book or guide. This book provides step-by-step detail about everything required for the event. It provides the MICE planner with all the pertinent information during the event, thus allowing that person to check all room setups, audiovisual needs, and so forth.

On-site Activities

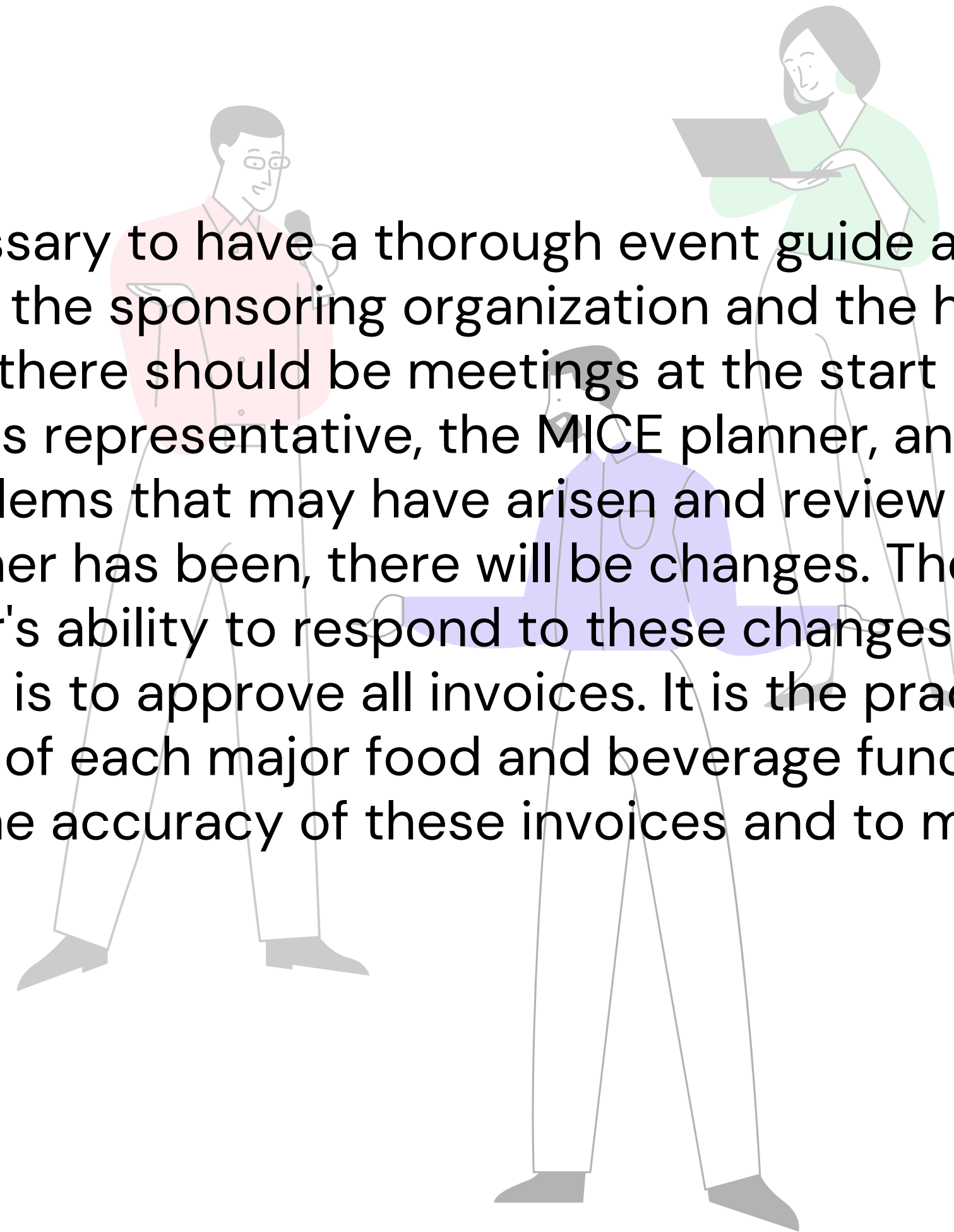
The MICE planner should arrive at least one hour before the event in the case of a single meeting. In case of a major convention or exposition, the MICE planner should arrive several days before the event to oversee the move-in activities. During the move-in process, the MICE planner will work closely with facility managers and other individuals responsible for the successful execution of the event. The MICE planner acts as the director of the move-in process and coordinates the functions of these key individuals.

When an event is sponsored by an association, the MICE planner will work with the executive staff as well as the association members who work with the executive staff and volunteer committees. Before the move-in, those individuals involved should be trained in their respective roles. During the event, communication lines should remain open between all key players. Open communication is maintained through pre-convention meetings. Regardless of the size of the event, there should always be a pre-event briefing meeting to ensure that all the bases are covered. Pre-event briefing meetings should include all responsible individuals on the venue's staff. These individuals could include the general manager, salesperson, convention service manager, catering manager, chef, front desk manager, and room division manager.

The sponsoring organization should be represented by those individuals who have management responsibilities. If the sponsoring organization is an association, those attending the meeting could include the president, vice president, secretary, treasurer, and the association's professional staff. During the pre-event briefing, the participants will brief each other regarding the changes that have taken place since the event guide was developed. Each department head will discuss the arrangements he or she has made to service the group. After the pre-event briefing, the MICE planner and his or her staff will monitor all events to ensure that the needs of the attendees are being met. They are also responsible for managing all the people associated with the meeting to be sure that the plan is properly executed.

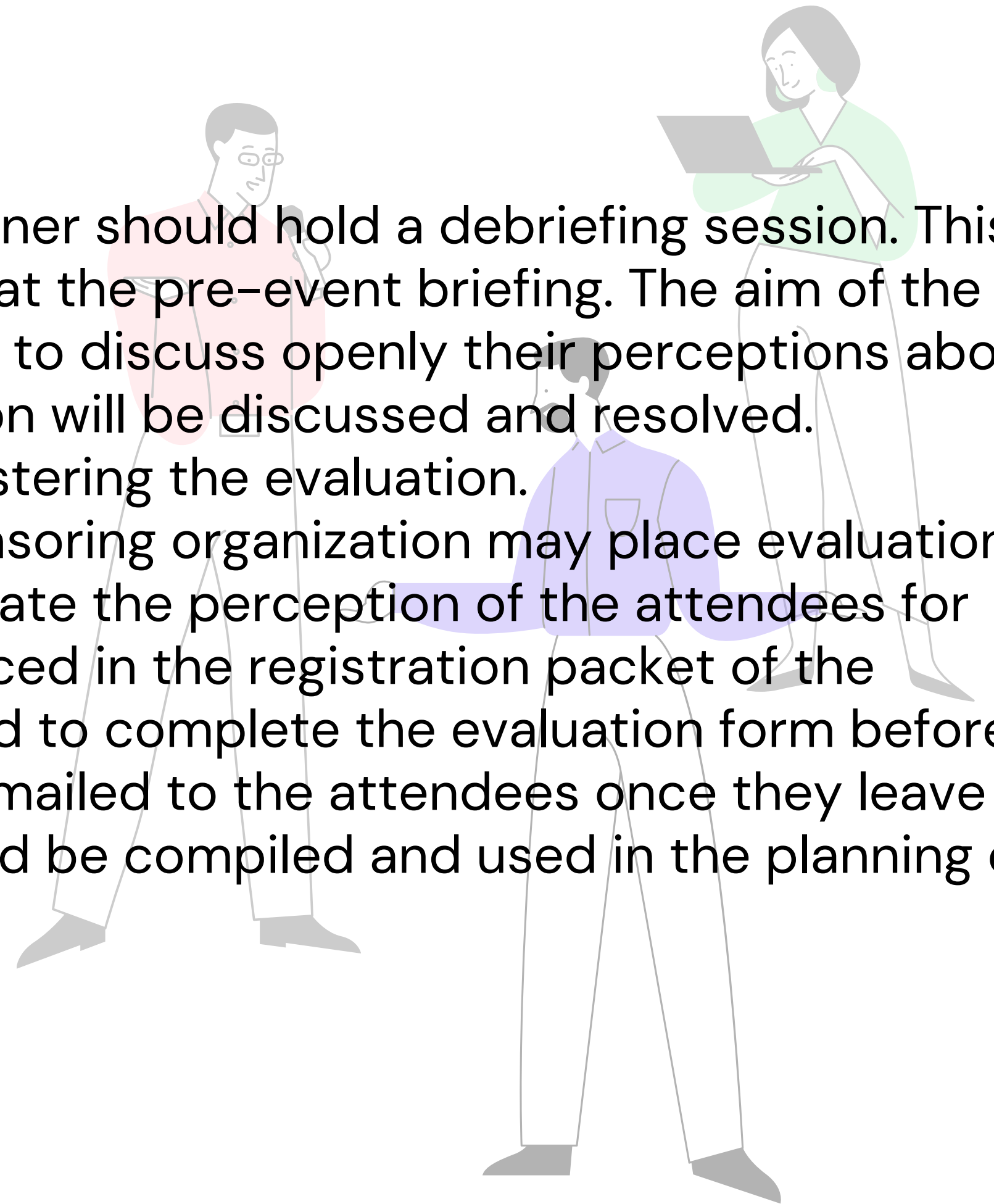


In order to execute the plan properly, it is necessary to have a thorough event guide and maintain open lines of communication between the sponsoring organization and the host venue. If the event lasts for more than one day; there should be meetings at the start of each day to enable the sponsoring organization's representative, the MICE planner, and the convention service coordinator to discuss problems that may have arisen and review the changes made. No matter how thorough a planner has been, there will be changes. The success of the event will depend on the planner's ability to respond to these changes. Another important function of the MICE planner is to approve all invoices. It is the practice of host venues to present an invoice at the end of each major food and beverage function. It is the responsibility of the planner to check the accuracy of these invoices and to make the necessary changes, if any.

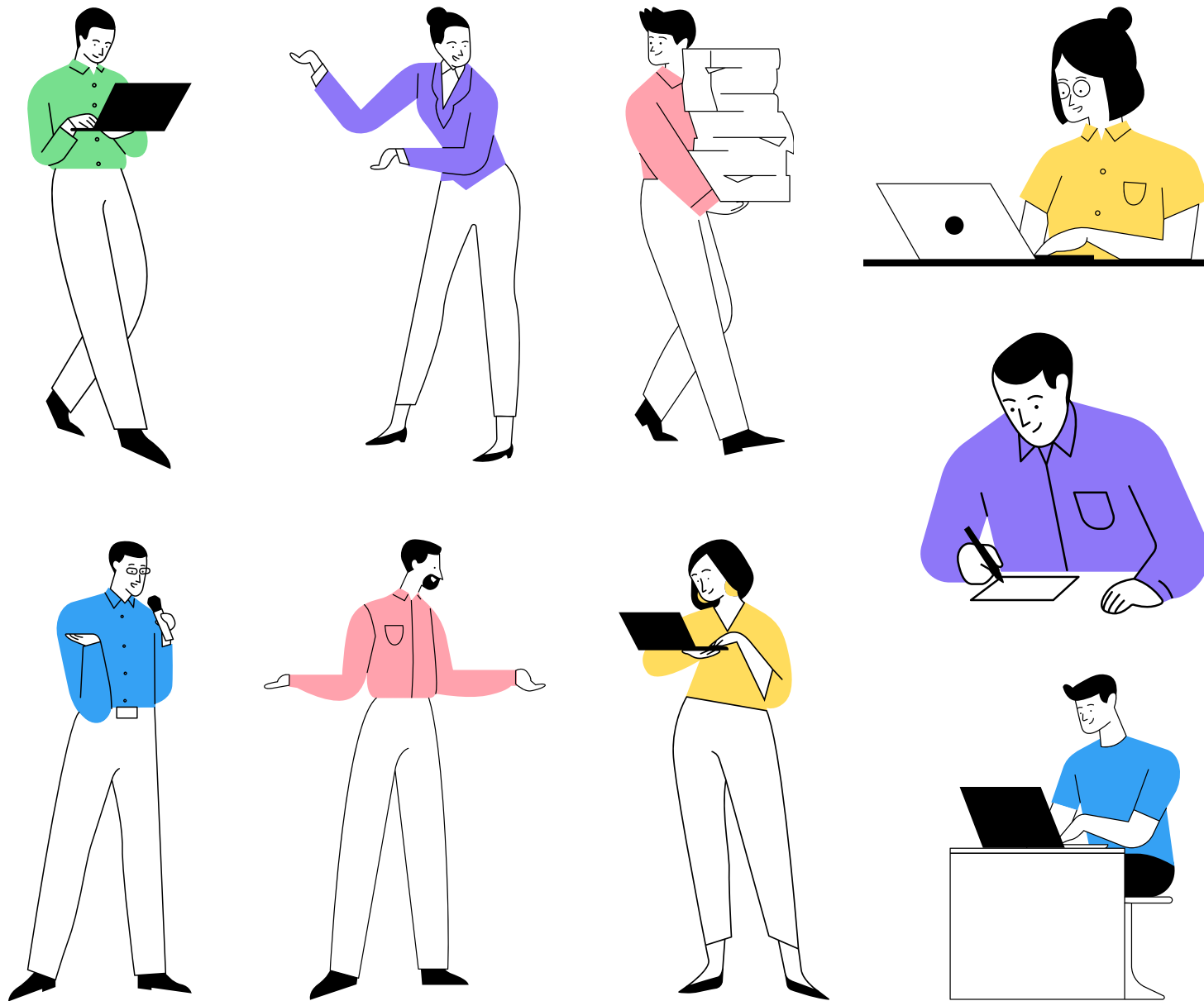


Post-meeting Activities

After the conclusion of the event, the MICE planner should hold a debriefing session. This meeting should include all the persons present at the pre-event briefing. The aim of the debriefing sessions is to allow all those involved to discuss openly their perceptions about the meeting. At this time, the items of contention will be discussed and resolved. The MICE planner is also responsible for administering the evaluation. This can be done in a number of ways. The sponsoring organization may place evaluation information in every session so that it can evaluate the perception of the attendees for each event. An evaluation form may also be placed in the registration packet of the attendees, and attendees should be encouraged to complete the evaluation form before they leave the site. The evaluation may also be mailed to the attendees once they leave the meeting. A summary of the evaluation should be compiled and used in the planning of future events.



SUMMARY



At present, the job of planning a meeting is recognized as a career. A few years ago, it was generally believed that anybody could plan a meeting and that there were no special skills required for it. However, as meetings have become more sophisticated, so have those individuals who plan them.

Today, there are several people who may have the responsibility of planning a meeting. These individuals may work for an association, corporation, government, travel agency, or themselves. Regardless of who they work for, the job of planning a meeting requires many pre-meeting activities, on-site supervision and coordination during the meeting, as well as post-meeting follow-up and evaluation. This chapter introduced the characteristics and responsibilities of MICE planners.